

helmets, carbines, night vision devices and lightweight bulletproof vests. Most of these are stuck at various stages of red tapism in two buildings: Sena Bhavan and South Block. Even critical urban counter-terrorism equipment to be fast-tracked or delivered within six months of the 26/11 attacks is still 18 months away.

The army reckons its infantry units—380 infantry battalions and 64 Rashtriya Rifles battalions (each with 850 men)—have a 50 to 70 per cent shortage of night sights. This “colossal shortage” of night vision devices means they cannot see the terrorists or fire accurately at them. Troops in J&K move around in unprotected vehicles because 225 Mine Protected Vehicles (MPV) are yet to be delivered by the Ordnance Factory Board (OFB). “By not keeping up with infantry modernisation, we are not only losing out on our deterrent capability but also our dissuasive capability because these are the weapons that come into play in counter-insurgency or wars below the nuclear threshold that the army envisages it will fight,” says Malik. A senior army official dealing with procurement says there are 18 different agencies in the Defence Ministry which have to work together to ensure timely acquisition. “The acquisition of a system is supposed to take 48 months. But the actual time is between seven to eight years,” says the official, blaming the bureaucracy.

“The Defence Procurement Procedure (DPP) is refined every year in consultation with the Indian Army; if there are delays they are equally to blame,” says former defence secretary Ajai Vikram Singh. “There are in-built safeguards in the system to ensure it is not corrupted but we have to ensure there is a fair balance between probity and acquisition timelines,” he says. Amidst the familiar finger-pointing in the Defence Ministry, it is the field army which suffers. “The infantryman is poorly trained and equipped, high on bravado and low on equipment and training. I would give him a 3/10,” says Lt-General H. S. Panag, former north-



A Long Wait

Basic arms and ammunition are caught up in the bureaucratic maze

THE OLD ORDER

NEW ASSAULT RIFLE TO REPLACE INSAS

DATE: FIRST PROPOSED IN 2008

STATUS: Case yet to be approved by MoD

2 LAKH CARBINES TO REPLACE 9 MM CARBINES

DATE: FIRST PROPOSAL IN 2007

STATUS: No decision for past 2 years

NEW GENERATION GRENADES TO REPLACE THE 36-M

DATE: OFB REPLACEMENT MODEL OKAYED IN 2008

STATUS: OFB can provide only 50,000 new grenades per year

15,000 NEW GENERAL PURPOSE MACHINE GUNS

DATE: FIRST FLOATED IN 2008

STATUS: Yet to be cleared

1087 NEW LIGHTWEIGHT ANTI MATERIAL RIFLES (AMR)

DATE: CASE PENDING SINCE 2006

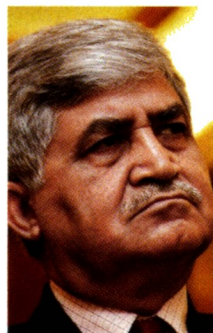
STATUS: Yet to be approved



“BY NOT KEEPING UP WITH INFANTRY MODERNISATION,

WE ARE NOT ONLY LOSING OUR DETERRENT CAPABILITY BUT OUR DISSUASIVE CAPABILITY AS WELL.”

GENERAL (retd) V. P. MALIK



FROM KNEE AND ELBOW PADS TO BOOTS, TROOPS LACK BASIC PROTECTIVE GEAR

AP PHOTO/DAR YASIN

